STATE OF WORRY

When AAP stormed to power with a massive mandate in Punjab, the 49-year-old Bhagwant Mann inherited a state that was already in a mess. Soon, fresh trouble began brewing on all fronts: be it gangland violence, religious radicalism or fiscal peril. A year later, the gloom is only deepening

IT was just a year ago that Bhagwant Mann and the Aam Aadmi Party (AAP) stormed to power in Punjab with a landslide victory after the electorate turned its back on the state's two most powerful parties—the Congress and the Akali Dal (SAD)—that had taken turns to rule the frontline state since it came into existence in 1966. The 49-year-old Mann, like the Ukrainian president Volodymyr Zelensky, was a popular comedian before he turned to politics. His promise of *badlav*, or change, along with the freshness that AAP brought with it, had wowed voters who were disillusioned with the shenanigans of the state's seasoned parties.

Yet when Mann completes one year as chief minister of the first AAP government in Punjab on March 16, the euphoria among voters will seem to have noticeably dissipated. Mann did inherit a state with an ailing, debt-ridden economy wrought by two decades of Sikh militancy and an over-exploitation of its natural resources that caused widespread unrest among farmers and unemployed youth, not to mention rising drug addiction and lawlessness. It was going to be an uphill task for any political leader to administer such a troubled state and turn it around. And Mann was a complete rookie. There were also no quick-fix solutions.

A year on, therefore, Mann has yet to prove himself as the man for the job. Punjab finds itself in a fresh upsurge of social ferment, with religious hardliners going on a rampage, serious lapses in law and order and the state's financial health turning even more precarious, with major revenue shortfalls and not enough money to pay salaries to government officers on time. "Unfortunately, so far, Mann and his party have neither exhibited a sense of history nor shown the vision to tackle the multifarious problems the state faces," says Dr Pramod Kumar, a prominent development expert and political commentator. "They appear disconnected from Punjab's history and social reality and appear to be muddling their way through. That's why the state remains in a mess."

REVIVAL OF SIKH RADICALISM

The state, always prone to a touch of restiveness, is witnessing a worrying surge in Sikh radical sentiments, and that has seen the law and order situation take a turn for the worse. Trouble began almost from the start of Mann's innings. In June last year, pro-Khalistan leader Simranjit Mann stunned the newly victorious AAP by defeating its candidate Gurmail

KILLING SPREE

Gangsters, victims & the Khalistani hand

↘ May 9, 2022: Rocket attack on Punjab Police Intelligence HQ



↘ May 29: Singer-rapper **Sidhu Moosewala murdered** in Mansa; six shooters identified



↘ Jul. 5: Facing criticism on law and order front, AAP government packs off DGP V.K. Bhawra, replaces him with **IPS officer Gaurav Yadav**



↘ Nov. 5: Shiv Sena (Taksali) leader **Sudhir Suri killed** in Amritsar

↘ Nov. 10: Dera Sacha Sauda follower **Pradeep Singh shot dead**; Canada-based gangster Goldy Brar takes responsibility

↘ Nov. 11: Four of six **Moosewala killers arrested**, two killed in encounter. Delhi Police arrest suspected killers of Dera man Pradeep Singh

↘ Dec. 9: **Rocket attack** on police station in Tarn Taran

↘ Jan. 25, 2023: Main accused in May rocket attack, **Deepak Ranga,** a close associate of Canada-based gangster-terrorist Lakhbir Singh Sandhu, alias Landa arrested

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